MEAL PLANNING

Plan a week of meals in 20 minutes, shop once, waste less, and keep leftovers safe.

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GUIDE / VERIFY: General wellness information, not medical advice. It does not replace care from a doctor, nurse, pharmacist or other qualified professional. **Talk to your health-care provider before starting a new exercise, diet or health plan, especially if you have a medical condition.**

1. FIVE STEPS

1. **Check what you have.** Look in the fridge, freezer and pantry first. Plan meals that use what needs using.
2. **Pick the meals.** Plan dinners first; breakfasts and lunches can repeat. Choose a few you know well and at most one new recipe a week.
3. **Plan for leftovers.** Cook once, eat twice: tonight's roast chicken is tomorrow's soup or sandwiches.
4. **Write the shopping list** by store section (below), and stick to it.
5. **Prep ahead.** Wash and cut vegetables, cook a pot of grains or beans, portion snacks. An hour on the weekend saves time all week.

- Build meals the simple way: half vegetables and fruit, a quarter protein, a quarter whole grains. *(WL-03)*
- Keep a list of 10 to 15 meals your household likes and rotate them.
- Budget: beans, eggs, oats, frozen vegetables, canned fish and whole chickens are low-cost protein and produce.
- Plan one "use it up" night a week for leftovers.

2. WEEKLY PLAN

DAY	BREAKFAST	LUNCH	DINNER	SNACKS / NOTES
MON				
TUE				
WED				
THU				
FRI				
SAT				
SUN				

3. SHOPPING LIST

PRODUCE	PROTEIN / DAIRY	PANTRY / GRAINS	FROZEN / OTHER

4. LEFTOVERS AND FOOD SAFETY

RULE	DETAIL
Refrigerate within 2 hours	Within 1 hour if it's above 90°F (a hot car, a picnic). Divide big batches into shallow containers so they cool fast.
Eat within 3 to 4 days	Leftovers in the fridge. Label containers with the date.
Freeze for longer	Frozen food stays safe indefinitely at 0°F; quality is best within a few months.
Reheat to 165°F	Use a food thermometer. Bring sauces, soups and gravies to a boil.
Fridge 40°F or below; freezer 0°F	Keep an appliance thermometer in each.

5. OUR GO-TO MEALS

MEAL	MAIN INGREDIENTS	LEFTOVERS BECOME

SOURCES / FURTHER REFERENCE

1. U.S. Departments of Health and Human Services and Agriculture: Dietary Guidelines for Americans, 2025–2030. `dietaryguidelines.gov`
2. USDA / FoodSafety.gov: Leftovers and Food Safety; Cold Food Storage Chart. `foodsafety.gov`

IMPORTANT: Ask a registered dietitian if you need a plan for a medical condition, allergy or special diet.